2B (or Not 2B)

By Jacquelyn Reingold

(FRANNY, *upset, disheveled, in her studio apartment, on the phone, She talks fast.)*

FRANNY: I know you told me it was over and I respect that. I mean, I understand it and I know you don't want to see me again and I know I was not very nice to you at times, and I just want to say that I've had a-well, a complete not-niceostomy and a total unlike-ectomy, I've had all the not-nice unlikable parts removed, so if you call me, I'm sure we can work it out. *(She hangs up. She cries. She dials.)* I can't believe you haven't called me back. I heard you asked out my friend Eleanor. Okay, well, thanks for breaking my heart. And I still really love you and if you want to change your mind and give it another try, let me know. *(Hangs up. Cries.) (A human-size bee appears.)* AHH!! *(She hides her head; she looks.)* Ohmigodohmigodohmigod!

Actors freeze then The BEE steps out of scene for the following introduction

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *(In the manner of . . .The Twilight Zone) A story of a woman living a life that is not-so-great and what happens when she is offered the opportunity of a lifetime: to be Queen Bee. 2B (or Not 2B) by Jacquelyn Reingold*

FRANNY: *(She tries to hide. The bee is huge. There's nowhere to go. She runs into a corner.)* Ohmigod. Okay. Could you just go? Please. Urn. Shoo. Go. *(He doesn't budge.)* Look, the park is a few blocks away. If you could just fly over there, I'm sure you'd be happier. *(He doesn't move. She crouches to the floor or hides under the bed.)* Or in the back, there's a garden. With, uh, plants. Or my neighbor

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downstairs, she has these window boxes: geraniums, impatiens. I'm sure you're in the wrong place.

BEE: Is this 2B?

FRANNY: What?

BEE: 2B or not 2B?

FRANNY: It's a joke, right?

BEE: I wouldn't make a joke like that.

FRANNY: Okay, this is 2B, but I'm sure it's the wrong building.

BEE: 344 West 188 Street?

FRANNY: *(Grabs her bag and tosses it at the bee.)* Okay, take whatever you want. I only have ten dollars, but I'll write down my PIN number. My bank's on the corner, you can have it all.

BEE: I don't want your money.

FRANNY: Then take the TiVo. Or the organic honey, okay?

BEE: I don't want that.

FRANNY: Look, I'm possibly allergic. And my EpiPen will not be of much use in this case, , cause you are ohmigod so big. You are the biggest bee I have ever seen. I can't believe this is happening.

BEE: [Frank]'s a jerk. Forget about him.

FRANNY: What?

BEE: You deserve better.

FRANNY: Well, thank you, I will consider that. Now please, go away. Or I'll call the police.

BEE: I don't think they'll come for a bee.

FRANNY: I am really afraid of you. I mean, really afraid. Bees are my ... well, thing. You know, some people it's snakes or heights or whatever, but me, it's bees.

BEE: Why would I hurt you?

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FRANNY: I don't know. Because you're a bee.

BEE: Have you been hurt before?

FRANNY: Yes.

BEE: Yellow jackets.

FRANNY: No, bee. Bees. I've been stung. So I am sure you are in the wrong apartment.

BEE: It's the right apartment.

FRANNY: Then it's the wrong species. I'm a human, a female human, and you're not invited.

BEE: How's that going for you?

FRANNY: What?

BEE: Being a female human?

FRANNY: It's fine. It's just fine.

BEE: Work and love, it's all good? How's your job? (FRANNY *sneaks toward the window while talking.)*

FRANNY: Fine. I'm a receptionist. It's a career change. I used to be a painter. Very cutting edge, I didn't even use paint, I used body fluids. But um, it didn't work out because several others already claimed that niche. You wouldn't believe what some people do with their menstrual blood. So now I, uh, have a job and a boss and uh- *(She can't get out the window.)*

BEE: And your human female love life? (FRANNY *crawls all around the room, heading toward a certain cabinet while talking.)*

FRANNY: Well, my first relationships were with typical self-involved commitmentphobes when I was between the ages of, say, five and twelve. Then junior high was alcoholics; high school was drug addicts; college, gay men, a guy who owned a duck, then a physically challenged interpretive ice skater, meaning you know an amputee who'd skate with a kind of stick with

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a blade at the bottom. Then I married a guy who liked to put garlic in his ears, but I went away a lot with my boyfriend, who was a puppeteer for the blind. (FRANNY *has snuck around to her cabinet, pulled out a can of bug spray, and points it at the bee.)* Okay, get out. Or I will spray you with this deadly spray. *(She sprays. The can is empty. She shakes, tries again, nothing.)* Damn. *(She runs for the door. It won't open.)*

BEE: You like flowers, don't you, Franny?

FRANNY: How do you know my name?

BEE: Do you know how intoxicatingly beautiful you are?

FRANNY: Now, *that's* a joke.

BEE: We find you unbearably sexy.

FRANNY: Who's we?

BEE: We know you haven't even begun to tap into your [womanly] capacity.

FRANNY: What's that smell?

BEE: That's my nectar.

FRANNY: Mmm. Not bad.

BEE: Franny Dambrose, you are wonderfully demanding, fascinatingly moody, exquisitely impossible to please.

FRANNY: Well ...

BEE: Complicated, codependent, and controlling. Perfect in all ways.

FRANNY: Well ...

BEE: We want to give you everything you always wanted, but thought you couldn't have: love, fulfillment; we will serve your every need.

FRANNY: Well ...

BEE: We want you to be our Queen.

FRANNY: What?

BEE: We've watched you. We've chosen you. We know you.

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FRANNY: What is this?

BEE: You can run, but you can't hive. We even have a sense of humor.

FRANNY: Hardly.

BEE: Just think: You wouldn't have to work. You'd have plenty of time: to read, to lounge, to do your art. Think what you could paint with pollen.

FRANNY: That's very nice of you, but hey, why don't you get, um, a real bee? I know you could find one in, um, the park.

BEE: We had a bad experience. She was a ... killer. So we've opted for this scientifically advanced entomologically evolutionary revolutionary solution. We find a very special human female and offer her a better life. Works well for all involved.

FRANNY: If it works so well, what happened to your last one?

BEE: She fell in love with a wasp. Not recommended. The children will be confused.

FRANNY: Okay.

BEE: Franny, imagine yourself as Queen. You'd never be alone again on a Friday night. You'd be serving the greater good by helping to cross-pollinate. Not to mention, we will please you in every way.

FRANNY: Well, urn, look, it's nothing personal, but I find you, I'm sorry to say, physically, uh, repulsive.

BEE: Oh, I think that could change.

FRANNY: And I'm human.

BEE: That too can change. Amelia Earhart? She didn't disappear. She made a choice. So can you.

FRANNY: But what's wrong with being human?

BEE: Have you read the paper lately? Your species isn't exactly living up to its potential.

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FRANNY: Amelia Earhart?

BEE: I don't want to rush you, Franny, except that my brothers and cousins are eagerly waiting and time is quickly running out. Don't you want what I've offered? What is it you're reluctant to give up?

FRANNY: Well, my apartment.

BEE: A studio in Inwood?

FRANNY: It's near the subway.

BEE: You'd have your own hive.

FRANNY: My job.

BEE: That job sucks.

FRANNY: And there's Frank.

BEE: Frank is a fly, a gnat, a roach. Besides, he's an actor. Forget Frank.

FRANNY: Believe me, I've tried.

BEE: Franny, oh, Franny, have you looked at your life lately?

FRANNY: I prefer not to.

BEE: All of your qualities that absolutely don't work as a female human will work like gangbusters as a bee.

FRANNY: Things'll get better.

BEE: How long have you been saying that?

FRANNY: Time heals all wounds.

BEE: Weren't you the queen in your grade school play? Didn't you enjoy it?

FRANNY: I loved it. But I didn't get to keep the crown. I wanted that crown.

BEE: You could have a crown.

FRANNY: But still, I'm terrified of you. I see a bee, I flee. It's a kind of a flight-or-flight kind of thing. I don't go on picnics, I avoid practically the entire outdoors because of you.

BEE: What exactly are you afraid of?

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FRANNY: Pain, death, dying alone, that sort of thing.

BEE: Touch my stinger.

FRANNY: What?

BEE: Touch it.

FRANNY: No.

BEE: Don't you think it's time to change?

FRANNY: That's a pretty big change.

BEE: I know you, Franny Dambrose. The reason you're afraid of me is because you *are* me. In your heart, you're a bee. Touch it. *(She touches it, pulls her hand away twice. Touches it.)*

FRANNY: Oh. Oh. It's-it's nice.

BEE: Isn't it?

FRANNY: And that smell. Your ... nectar.

BEE: Yes. *(A musical humming is heard. Lights change.)*

FRANNY: That sound. What is it?

BEE: My cousins and brothers. Here to serve you.

FRANNY: Oh my. *(She begins to transform into a be – Wings, antennae.)* I feel ... different. What's your name?

BEE: Dave the *Bee*.

FRANNY: Hi, Dave. *(The phone rings.)*

BEE: Let it ring. It's time.

FRANNY: But ... What if it's Frank? *(She answers the phone.)* Hello? Frank? *(The lights change. The humming stops.)* I'm glad you called. What? You want me to stop calling? You're really happy since we broke up? You're still seeing my friend, Eleanor? You've asked her to marry you? Great. That's just great. *(As* FRANNY *is about to burst into tears and launch an attack, Dave puts a crown on her head. Voila. She is transformed. She nearly drops the phone.)* Frank, remember the Don't Bee and

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the Do *Bee?* Well, you are most definitely a Don't. And when it comes to you and your kind, I am done. Buzz off! *(She hangs up.)* Okay, boys, let's fly.

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